

offered gifts, usually anything they could afford, from a cup of wine to an animal such as a pig, a sheep, or a chicken. The bigger the animal, the greater the gift—and gifts didn't come much bigger or more expensive than an ox.

There were rules to follow when animals were slaughtered. Male animals were sacrificed to male gods, and female animals to goddesses. Some gods preferred certain animals; some religious festivals demanded pigs, not sheep; and so on.

After the animal had been knocked unconscious, its throat was cut—except if it was a chicken, in which case its neck was wrung. The dead animal was disemboweled and its guts were examined by priests (what a job!) in search of omens. A healthy liver was a good sign, but a diseased liver meant that someone was in for bad luck.

### Household shrines

You didn't have to take a trip to the local temple to offer a gift to the gods. Every Roman family—whether rich or poor—had an altar, or *lararium*, at home. The father, as head of the household, made offerings on behalf of his family. Each



JUPITER, KNOWN BY THE GREEKS AS ZEUS, WAS THE KING OF THE ROMAN GODS.

morning, he said prayers to the household spirits (*lares*) and left bread, fruit, and maybe some wine on the altar.

### Happy families

The Romans had a family of 12 main gods and goddesses. What a coincidence—so did the Greeks! Why? Well, the